

fridayReview

THE HINDU

The traditional line-up
Chitra Lakshumanan explored the many facets of the Bharatanatyam margam **p2**

Back to his first love
Anupam Kher returns to the stage with a new play, Jaane Pehchaane Anjane **p3**



BEETHOVEN AND HIS TIMELESS QUARTETS

French cellist
Gauthier Herrmann
and NCPA present
the composer's
masterpieces **p4**

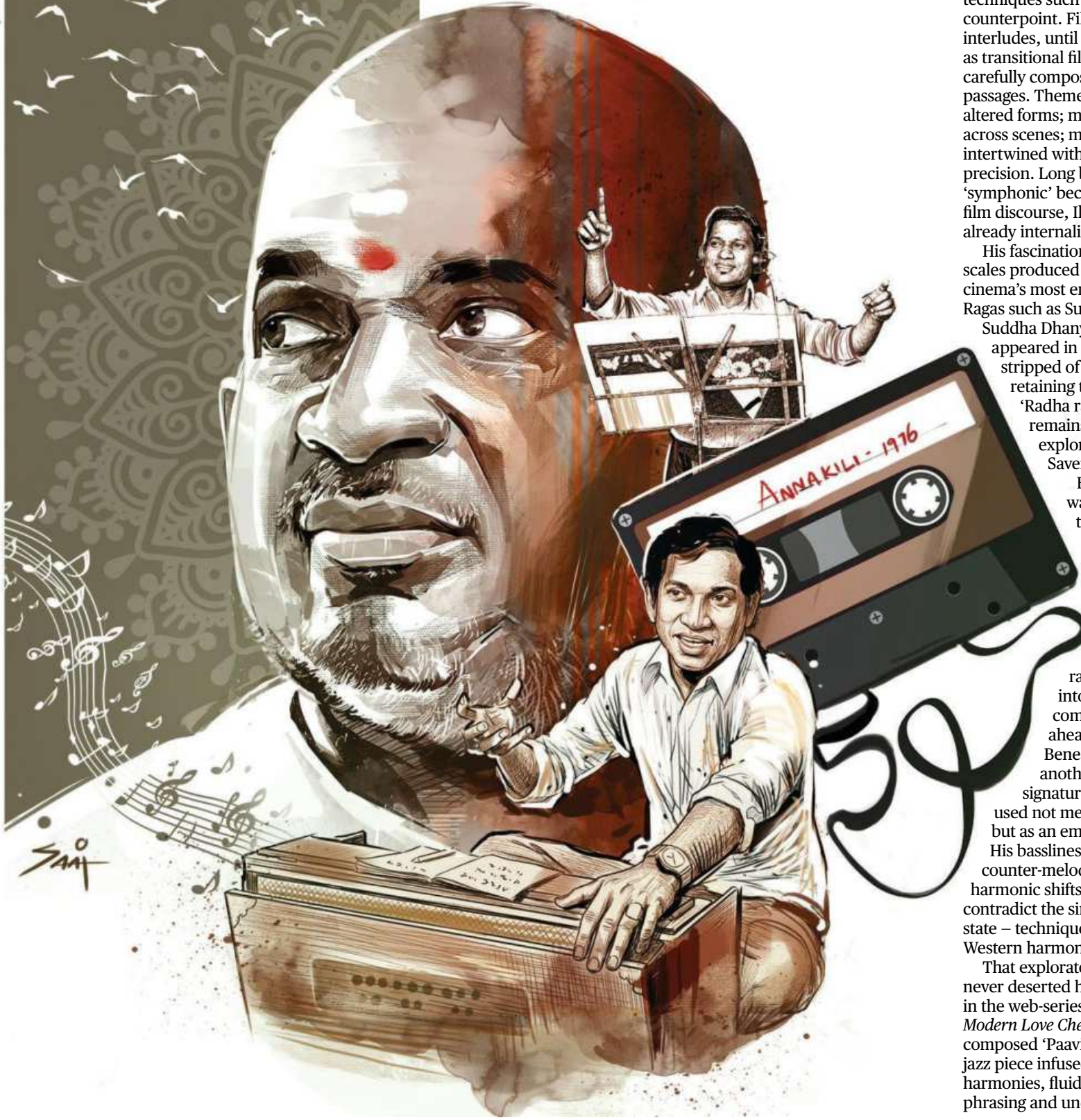
Kalyan Gopalan

On May 14, 1976, a quiet musical tremor began in Tamil cinema. Few could have imagined that the young composer from rural Tamil Nadu, making his debut with *Annakili*, would go on to alter the soundscape of Indian film music for generations. Fifty years later, Ilaiyaraaja remains not merely a composer but a phenomenon – a musician who dissolved the boundaries between folk idioms, Carnatic grammar, and Western classical architecture, returning them to listeners as something profoundly intimate and human. His journey is often described as extraordinary, but perhaps the more remarkable aspect is its rootedness. Every phase of his music carried the scent of the soil he came from. India changes every few hundred kilometres – language, dialect, rhythm, food, memory. Ilaiyaraaja absorbed these shifting landscapes with astonishing sensitivity. In his hands, a village lullaby could sit beside a Baroque counterpoint; a temple nagaswaram could converse effortlessly with a jazz bassline. Yet none of it felt imposed. His music belonged equally to the scholar and the farmer, the conservatory and the tea-shop radio. The opening hum of ‘Annakkili unnai theduthē’ still lingers in collective memory like mist over paddy fields. It announced not just a new composer but a new emotional grammar for Tamil cinema. Melodies became lived experiences. Background scores stopped merely accompanying scenes and lent depth to them. For many listeners, Ilaiyaraaja's music was not entertainment alone; it became part of the emotional architecture of their lives. To reduce his genius to a ‘Top 10 songs’ list is impossible. The true measure of his artistry often lies in his lesser-known experiments, in the musical risks tucked away inside obscure films and forgotten albums. One such early moment came with ‘Oru naal unnodu oru naal’, inspired partly by the rhythmic groove of ‘Come September’, at the urging of drummer Noel Grant. The song also marked an important milestone – one of the earliest recordings of S.P. Balasubrahmanyam for Ilaiyaraaja. Around the same period, a playful spoof of ‘Kabhi Kabhie’, rendered by T.M. Soundararajan, revealed the composer's ease with parody and adaptation without sacrificing originality.



Half a century after maestro
Ilaiyaraaja's debut as a
composer, his music continues
to defy categorisation,
dissolving boundaries
between folk idioms, Carnatic
grammar and Western
classical architecture

Eternal experimenter



Even as his workload multiplied, Ilaiyaraaja remained a relentless student of music. Under the guidance of Dhanraj Master and through formal study in Western classical composition, he sharpened his understanding of harmony, orchestration, and symphonic structure. These learnings quietly entered his cinema music. In *Kovil Pura*, for instance, the nagaswaram was not treated as decorative accompaniment but as the emotional spine of the film. In ‘Amuthē tamizhe’, the instrument flows through the interludes with devotional intensity, transforming the song into something close to a temple procession. A more radical example arrived in the little-known ‘Eeravizhi kaaviyangaal’. Today regarded as a cult work among music enthusiasts, the film revealed Ilaiyaraaja's extraordinary command of Western classical techniques such as fugue and counterpoint. Film-song interludes, until then often treated as transitional fillers, became carefully composed orchestral passages. Themes returned in altered forms; motifs evolved across scenes; melodies intertwined with mathematical precision. Long before the word ‘symphonic’ became fashionable in film discourse, Ilaiyaraaja had already internalised its grammar. His fascination with pentatonic scales produced some of Tamil cinema's most enduring melodies. Ragas such as Suddha Saveri and Suddha Dhanyasi frequently appeared in his compositions, stripped of rigidity yet retaining their classical soul. ‘Radha radha nee enge’ remains an elegant early exploration of Suddha Saveri. Equally striking was his willingness to venture into less-travelled ragas. In *Kadal Meengal*, the song “Endrendrum Aanandhame” transformed the rare Sarasangi raga into a vibrant pop composition decades ahead of its time. Beneath the melody lay another Ilaiyaraaja signature: the bass guitar used not merely for rhythm but as an emotional narrator. His basslines often introduce counter-melodies, anticipate harmonic shifts, or even contradict the singer's emotional state – techniques rooted deeply in Western harmonic thinking. That exploratory instinct has never deserted him. Decades later, in the web-series anthology *Modern Love Chennai*, Ilaiyaraaja composed ‘Paavi Nenje’, a pure jazz piece infused with smoky harmonies, fluid improvisational phrasing and understated vocal

expression. Even in his seventies, he continued to be curious. Among his most fascinating experiments is *Sindhu Bhairavi*. In one unforgettable sequence, the protagonist – torn between desire and artistic purity – attempts to steady himself through music. Ilaiyaraaja chose the raga Kanakangi, the first *melakarta* in Carnatic music, for this psychological breakdown. As the song intensifies and the tanpura strings snap, the music mirrors the protagonist's collapse. It was not merely background scoring; it was musical dramaturgy. Another underappreciated masterpiece is *Mogamul*. Several songs in the film revolve around ragas ending with ‘priya’ – Ramapriya, Shanmukhapriya, Natakapriya, Rasikapriya. Whether intentional or instinctive, the thematic choice feels deeply linked to the emotional core of the narrative: love, longing, tenderness, desire. Ilaiyaraaja's background score, in the scene where an elderly man gifts a silk saree to his young wife lasts barely two minutes, yet it leaves behind an ache that dialogue alone could never create. He is also an accomplished lyricist. In the unreleased film *Kaathal Saathi*, his song ‘Kaathe kaathe’ reflects a deeply personal conversation with nature: ‘The forest stands alone; so do I. The forest is my companion, and I am its companion. Among countless wildflowers, I too am but one wildflower.’ The lines reveal the solitude that often accompanies genius – austere, unadorned, yet quietly luminous. Outside cinema, too, Ilaiyaraaja sought new musical terrains. His non-film works, including ‘How to name it?’ and ‘Nothing but wind’, remain landmark explorations in Indian contemporary music. The piece ‘Mozart, I Love You’, featuring Hariprasad Chaurasia, later found renewed life in *Geethanjali*, proving how fluidly his compositions travelled across forms and contexts. Half a century after *Annakili*, Ilaiyaraaja's music still resists categorisation. It is at once scholarly and accessible, rooted and borderless, mathematical and deeply emotional. Generations have changed, technologies have evolved and listening habits have fragmented, yet his compositions continue to breathe through transistor radios, temple festivals, concert halls, streaming playlists, and solitary midnight drives. Perhaps that is the true measure of his legacy: Ilaiyaraaja did not merely compose songs; he composed memories.

Pathway to music mastery

Applications are invited for an Advanced Diploma course in Carnatic Music, conducted by the Music Academy Madras. The three-year programme begins in July 2026, with two semesters each year – mid-July to November end and mid-January to April end. Examinations will be held at the close of every semester. Classes will be on Monday to Friday, between 8a.m. and 12.30p.m., and eligibility is restricted to students aged between 18 and 30 years, who have passed +2 and can sing varnams, kritis, and demonstrate manodharma. The Advanced School of Carnatic Music, established in 2010, has trained students under stalwarts and at the end of the three-year course, students are tested on compositions, niraval, and must present a full concert before an invited audience. Visit musicacademymadras.in to access the application form. June 15 is the last date to apply. For details, call 044-2811 2231, 044-2811 6902, 044-2811 5162.

Celebrating the repertoire

Natyarangam, the dance wing of Narada Gana Sabha Trust, presents Poorna Margam by Anjana Anand on May 23 (4 p.m.) at the sabha's mini hall. Anjana will lead the audience through the arc of margam, from the invocatory alarippu to the concluding tillana. Started in 2014, Poorna Margam, an initiative of the sabha, promotes the beauty and purpose of Bharatanatyam's traditional repertoire as envisioned by the Thanjavur Quartet. Each year, two recitals are presented in the third week of the month. The event is open to all.



Dance of the cosmic rhythm

‘Sivapadam – Natya Vaibhavam’ – a classical dance-ballet, portraying the eternal cycle of creation, sustenance, and dissolution will be staged on May 23 (5 p.m.) at New Horizon College of Engineering auditorium, Marathahalli, Bengaluru. Written and narrated by Brahmasri Samavedam Shanmukha Sarma, and featuring Sri Shraavan and troupe, the choreography fuses classical dance styles with Vedantic wisdom. Chief guests for the evening will be Mohan Manghnani, Tejasvi Surya, and Shatavadhani R. Ganesh. The event is open to all.



Choreography sessions

Sumanasa Foundation is organising a workshop by well-known Bharatanatyam artiste and choreographer Parshwanath Upadhye. Part of a series the foundation has curated since 2021, the workshop, titled ‘Choreography - From ideation to the stage’, will be held online on May 23 and 24 (9 p.m. IST). Open to dancers from all disciplines, it will guide participants in developing compositions during the sessions, while breaking down its structure and offering sharing insights into the diverse methods, approaches and creative processes behind choreography. After the workshop, registered participants will receive view-only access to the session recording. Proceeds will support marginalised artistes and creative communities. For registration: sumanasafoundation.org/wb

A multi-media production by Ghirija Jayarraj explored dance, displacement and dreams

Dance of the wanderlust

V.V. Ramani

Places, experiences and memories that shape an individual during their formative years often sow the seeds of their adult persona. For artistes, these impressions find expression in their creative pursuits. ‘Wanderland’, a multi-media production by Shastram, conceived by writer-director Ghirija Jayarraj and recently presented at Alliance Française, was one such work – inviting us to journey with her through an artistic path shaped across geographical boundaries. The performance unfolded as a series of fragmented visuals. Film footage of places and people from varied backgrounds across different time zones, archival scrapbook pictures, recent photographs and interviews played on the screen. Interspersed with



Creative world
'Wanderland' was a cohesive collage of music, dance, theatre and film. PHOTOS: OWEN GREGORY AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

these were live dance performances and theatrical sequences woven into the narrative – gradually merging into a cohesive collage of forms and memories. Moving between Sri Lanka, India and Australia – the three places that moulded her life – the narrative offers

insight into Ghirija’s varied experiences: from displacement and family travails during wartime in Sri Lanka to her new beginnings in Australia. Grappling with a sense of belonging, she sought refuge in Bharatanatyam, reconnecting with her

cultural heritage to navigate an identity crisis. Dance sequences in varied styles, performed with finesse by Avijit Das, Prateeksha Kashi, Sruthi K.P., and Shwetha Krishna, along with younger dancers – Shwetha Jaishree, Sreejith and Arivu Selvan – were seamlessly integrated

into the film’s narrative. Short anecdotes and stories accompanying each segment were both engaging and clarifying, underscoring their relevance to the theme. Cinematography and art direction were by Pradeep Kaliyapurath. The presentation sought to build a bridge between past and present through the struggles of displaced communities and individuals. However, the numerous pieces of footage featuring conversations with dance gurus, combined with an excess of scrapbook images, diluted the seriousness of the production’s intention. Certain sections of theatrical interventions felt highly contrived and out of place. A tighter edit of the footage, perhaps, would have created a stronger impact. Overall, the performance moved beyond the realm of being a mere dance narrative, engaging the viewer and inspiring a mode of self-reflection. Earlier in the evening, another production, ‘Mukuti’, directed by Ghirija, was presented by Shruthi K.P. Using a simple nose ring as a metaphor, various questions about a dancer’s identity were explored through a blend of music, dance, theatre and film. The work traced the evolution of Mohiniattam through a film enactment anchored by a choreographic work of Nirmala Panicker. The world of Meenakshi, her passion for dance, the pressures of social structures and her emotions were beautifully captured on film. The live dance sequences did not match the impact of the screen. However, recurring references to the *mukuti* provided an interesting link, with parallel streams reflecting the dichotomy between two eras visualised effectively.



Resetting the morning hymn

Uthara Unnikrishnan reimagines ‘Suprabhatham’ for a new generation

Srinivasa Ramanujam

The Venkatesa Suprabhatham, composed in the 15th century, is a famous Sanskrit devotional hymn used to awaken Lord Venkateshwara at Tirupati. A widely heard devotional composition, it is typically played in many South Indian households at dawn. So it was at Uthara Unnikrishnan’s home as well. “My paternal grandmother listens to it every morning to this day. She also chants it with utmost devotion. The version she listens to is a rendition by the legendary MS Subbulakshmi, which is the track that plays in most households,” says the

21-year-old musician and daughter of popular singer, Unnikrishnan. Now Uthara has come up with a contemporary interpretation of this ancient work. “I want it to reach young listeners, but have retained the essence of the original.” Produced by Sandeep Reddy of Sea Records and programmed and arranged by composer, Prithvi Chandrashekar, the 20-minute song aims to create a meditative listening experience. Uthara was inspired by MS Subbulakshmi’s rendition of the hymn. “I didn’t listen to anything else,” she reveals and adds: “When this project came to me, I was overwhelmed because till then I had not focussed much on the lyrics. I was concerned about the perfect enunciation of the verses. Before recording, I read the Sanskrit version instead of the English. The faster portions were hard to master; it took me 10 hours to complete the entire track.” A popular film and classical singer, Uthara feels it is important to explore various musical styles. “Tomorrow, a film recording might require me to dabble in a genre I am not comfortable with, so it is important to expose yourself to different styles,” says the young artiste, who also recently released her rendition of the ‘Kandha Shasti Kavassam’ for Saregama India.

The song is out on audio streaming platforms and the lyric video will be out on May 23 on the Rajshri Soul Youtube channel.



Margam’s diverse strands

Chitra Lakshumanan showcased the many facets of the Bharatanatyam repertoire

Manasa Vijayalakshme C

The solo Bharatanatyam recital of Chitra Lakshumanan, disciple of Srekala Bharath, was presented as part of the HCL Concert Series at The Music Academy. Chitra commenced her performance with a shloka on Muruga, followed by the Shadakshara Kouthuvam in raga Shanmukhapriya and Rupaka tala, a composition by Madurai R. Muralidaran. Adorned in a vibrant green and red costume, the dancer showcased precise hand movements and sharp footwork, which lent grace and stability to the performance. Next came Mandooka Shabdam in Ragamalika and Misra Chapu, a composition of the Tanjore Quartet. It narrates the story of a frog seeking divine intervention and salvation. Chitra’s sensitive interpretation drew the audience into the essence of the story. It was choreographed by K.G. Sarasa, guru of Srekala Bharath. The centrepiece of the recital was the Swarajathi ‘E Mayaladira’ in raga Huseni, set to Rupaka tala, a composition by Ponniah Pillai of the Tanjore Quartet. It explored the anguish of a heroine troubled by her beloved’s changing behaviour and suspected disloyalty. Chitra conveyed the heroine’s emotions with finesse through expressive abhinaya and controlled movements, maintaining a fine balance between nritta and narrative expression. The second half of the recital featured the padam in tamil ‘Teruvil varano, ennai shatre tirumbip-parano’, a composition

by Muthu Thandavar in raga Khamas, set to Rupaka tala. The piece portrays a lovelorn devotee awaiting the procession of Lord Nataraja, yearning for a fleeting glance from the deity. This was followed by the Javali ‘Parulannamata’, a composition by Dharmapuri Subbarayar in raga Kaapi and Rupaka tala. Written from the perspective of a nayika addressing her beloved, the composition is a heartfelt plea for trust and affection. The recital concluded with a thillana in raga Paras, set to Adi tala, a composition by Poochi Srinivasa Iyengar. This was followed by an abhang, composed by Bhanu Dasa, which described the enchanting melody of Krishna’s flute resonating through Vrindavan and around the mighty Govardhana mountain. The composition depicted the enchanting effect of Krishna’s flute on all beings, including the dancing peacock reminiscent of Krishna himself. Chitra conveyed the devotional essence of the piece through spirited movements and evocative storytelling, bringing the recital to a close. The thoughtfully curated repertoire offered a pleasing variety of themes, emotions, and rhythmic textures, ensuring that the recital remained engaging throughout and never felt drawn out for the audience. The orchestra for the evening featured Preethy Mahesh on vocals, Sakthivel Muruganandam on the mridangam, and T. V. Sukanya on the violin. The choreography and nattuvangam were by Srekala Bharath, while the make-up was by Saraswathi.

Stories of forgotten soldiers

Kallabhiraamam felt more like a history lesson than a theatrical experience



Salute to valour A scene from the play. PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Suganthy Krishnamachari

In PMG Mayurapriya’s *Kallabhiraamam* (production: Vaishali Prasanth; story, dialogues, and direction: P. Muthukumaran), Akila (Anu Suresh) is engaged in research on unsung heroes of the freedom

movement. Major Jaswanth (Saiprasad Sriram), a family friend, advises her to focus instead on the Army’s unsung heroes, for they risk their lives so the rest of the country may live in peace. Akila is determined to marry someone who shares her passion for honouring those who have sacrificed for the nation. Her mother, who professes

her patriotism by singing ‘Saare jahan se accha’ on days of national importance, refuses to accept the idea of her daughter marrying a soldier, whose life is fraught with uncertainty. The play exposes the hypocrisy of those quick to praise the Army while ensuring that their own children are

comfortably settled abroad. The play also informs the audience about heroes on and off the battlefield. One such was Ravindra Kaushik, an undercover agent in Pakistan, who joined the military accounts department there and relayed vital intelligence to India until his identity was blown. He was imprisoned and later died. His sacrifice reminds of Churchill’s words: “So much owed by so many to so few”. Turning the spotlight on forgotten heroes is laudable, and the playwright has done ample research. But it felt as though Akila and Jaswanth were merely rattling off facts, making it seem more like a lecture on history than theatre. The play failed to evoke a reflective mood. The title *Kallabhiraamam* is from a verse, which says that a heroic stone installed for a warrior fallen in battle, is the most beautiful memorial in the world. The play, staged at the annual Kodai Nataka Vizha, concludes with plans to erect a statue for Singaram, a villager who fell to enemy bullets.

Fragments of childhood trauma

Tamil play *Kannamma* is a haunting tale of grief and retribution

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Jay Entertainers’ *Kannamma* (produced by M. Jansirani; story, dialogue, and direction by D. Mallikraj) opens with a chilling scene: the murder of a woman; and her 10-year-old daughter, Kannamma, who kills the murderer. She is sent to a reformatory school, where she spends her childhood. As a teenager, Kannamma is released, having used her time in the juvenile prison to improve her Tamil and poetry writing. Despite her achievements, angving her mother’s death remains her consuming obsession. Eventually, Kannamma tracks down the man behind

the murder and kills him. The sombre production portrayed a child’s innocence crushed by an adult motive for revenge. The play unfolded as a haunting tapestry of grief and fury, showing how trauma can shatter the fragile psyche of a child. As the story progresses, we realise that the greatest crime was not just the murder but also the psychological warping of the child. LED sets, designed by P. Lakshmi Narayanan, were a visual treat – the hilly beauty of Shimla with rich interiors of the houses, and the dank, forbidding corridors of the reformatory institution. But, there was one slip – there were coconut trees in

Shimla! There were also some missing threads, because of which continuity was lost. How did Lily (Barathi) zero in on a lawyer, who later turns out to be connected to the family? The motive for Lily’s murder was not explained. Saismruthi’s portrayal of the school girl, Kannamma, was realistic and the cold fury in her eyes was unsettling. Priya Kannamma, as the teenage-Kannamma also performed well. Fortunately, there was no heavy-handed moralising at the end of the play. The playwright showed the audience what grief does to a child who does not know how to process loss, and this had a lingering effect on the viewers.



Intriguing From *Kannamma*.staged at Kodai Nataka Vizha in Narada Gana Sabha PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

A photograph of a musician with long dark hair, wearing a yellow patterned shirt and light-colored trousers, playing a tabla. He is positioned in the foreground, surrounded by microphones and other musical equipment. Behind him is a large, ornate building with multiple levels of arched windows and balconies, all brightly lit with warm yellow light. The scene is set at night, with the building's lights creating a strong contrast against the dark sky.

A CH-CHE

Bindu Gopal Rao

Bach, Beethoven, Mozart and more come together in a compelling mix of celebrated masterpieces, lesser-known gems and unique reductions of iconic orchestral works at the 30th edition of Artie’s Festival India, which opened on May 20 and the next concert is on May 24 at the National Centre for the Performing Arts’ Experimental Theatre.

The festival balances renowned masterpieces with lesser-known compositions. “We are embarking on a great adventure: performing the complete cycle of Beethoven’s 16 string quartets. Two Beethoven quartets will be systematically performed in every concert we present over the next two years. The idea behind this programme, titled ‘Mostly Beethoven’, is to present one or two additional works – long or short, well known or waiting to be discovered – as windows opening into other musical horizons,” says Gauthier Herrmann, a celebrated French cellist, producer and co-founder of Artie’s Festival, who, along with Khushroo Suntook, chairman of the National Centre for the Performing Arts, devised the ‘Mostly Beethoven’ concept.

For this first series of concerts, we chose to perform orchestral works arranged for quartet. “It is refreshing not to have confined ourselves to the traditional string-quartet repertoire,” says Herrmann. Beethoven’s quartets are so monumental in their genius and craftsmanship that it is hard to find short pieces that don’t feel insignificant beside them. Also, 2027 will mark the 200th anniversary of Beethoven’s death, so the timing is perfect too.

Performing the complete

Revolutionary Quartets

The 30th edition of Artie’s Festival will present Beethoven’s 16 string quartets over two years, leading up to the 200th anniversary of his death



Chamber resonance
(Clockwise from left) Gauthier Herrmann; with musicians at last year’s edition of the festival. PHOTOS: COURTESY: NCPA



Beethoven’s quartets are often technically demanding and emotionally expansive. But they are not inaccessible, and you don’t need to be a specialist to appreciate them.

GAUTHIER HERRMANN

quartet cycle all at once, or even within a single year, did not seem the most suitable challenge for either the NCPA or its audience. From a performer’s perspective, it is a colossal undertaking, so it felt

more realistic to spread the project across two years. The aim is to complete the cycle by the end of 2027 through four two-week residencies in India.

Beethoven’s quartets are often technically demanding and emotionally expansive. “But they are not inaccessible, and you don’t need to be a specialist to appreciate them. What Beethoven managed to express with only four instruments is extraordinary. It is a journey of the soul that takes us through every emotion: joy, sorrow, energy, meditation, introspection, happiness, and nostalgia,” explains Herrmann. All the audience needs is curiosity and the willingness to step into the concert hall, he adds.

What is fascinating about the ‘Mostly Beethoven’ project is presenting the complete cycle as a whole. “For audience members who plan to attend all eight concerts – four in 2026 and four in 2027 – the experience will be extraordinary. Equally compelling are the works we’ve chosen to place in resonance with Beethoven’s quartets. For this edition, we will perform Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart’s Clarinet Quintet in A major, K. 581 – the

celebrated clarinet quintet. It was suggested by Khushroo Suntook, and we are delighted with the choice, as this masterpiece radiates pure joy,” shares Herrmann.

Over the past decade India’s chamber-music audience has matured, and at the NCPA it now draws many young listeners. “Many who are not classical-music enthusiasts are attending the concerts. We take pleasure in sharing this precious repertoire, which has accompanied us since youth. And, of course, everything evolves. When we first began in 2008, 30 editions ago, we focused exclusively on concerts: preparation and performance. Today, we work closely with social-media teams,” says Herrmann.

Looking ahead to the festival’s place in the international chamber-music scene, Herrmann says, Herrmann says: “We have been coming to India for more than 25 years, and our love for the country, its people, food and the concert atmosphere has only continued to grow. Personally, I have been to India more than 70 times, and I still prepare for these journeys with the same joy and excitement.”

CALENDAR

Memorial concert

Hamsadhwani presents an Anniversary Tribute Concert in memory of its founder R. Ramachandran Namasankeerthanam on May 23 at 6.30 p.m. The evening will feature Shencottai Hari Bhagavathar and party at Youth Hostel, Indira Nagar, Adyar.

Talk on temples

An illustrated lecture on ‘Ancient Temples of Tamil Nadu’ by historian Chithra Madhavan, organised by Tattvaloka, will be held on May 23, 6 p.m. Venue is Tattvaloka, Teynampet and it is open to all.

Sanskrit compositions

A programme of Sanskrit compositions will be presented this evening at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, 6 p.m. onwards, featuring Trivandrum Baby Sreeram on vocals, Thiruvizha Viju S. Anand on the violin and Mannarkoil J. Balaji on the mridangam. The event is organised under the endowment instituted by Engikollai Dr. C. Krishnan in memory of Sri Chidambara Ganapatigal and Smt. Meenakshi Chidambaram.



Stage stalwart honoured

Veteran actor S. Ve. Shekher was recently honoured with the Living Legend Award by Krishna Gana Sabha at its Summer Drama Festival. The award recognised Shekher’s journey in cinema, theatre and television. Known for his flair for humour, Shekher’s drama company Natakhapriya has been staging plays for over six decades. He has produced 24 plays and performed in more than 5000 shows. He has acted in more than 50 films and was also chairperson of the Central Board of Film Censors in Tamil Nadu.

Decoding Picasso’s visual language

The ongoing exhibition, ‘Picasso, the Figure’ at Louvre Abu Dhabi, reveals how he reshaped not only the human figure but the emotional vocabulary of art



Neeta Lal

At Louvre Abu Dhabi, art begins long before the first canvas comes into view. Beneath Jean Nouvel’s extraordinary floating dome – an architectural masterpiece that filters sunlight into a hypnotic ‘rain of light’ – visitors pause between sea-facing terraces and medina-inspired passageways. Conversations drift between admiration for the collection and awe at the building itself. Few cultural institutions manage to create such an immediate emotional atmosphere; fewer still make architecture feel inseparable from the art it houses.

This is precisely what makes Louvre Abu Dhabi unique. Rising from the waters of Saadiyat Island, like a contemporary cultural mirage, the museum reimagines what a global institution can be – not simply a repository of masterpieces, but a meeting point between East and West, antiquity and modernity, intimacy and scale.

Then you step into *Picasso, the Figure* and suddenly, the noise disappears.

Presented by Louvre Abu Dhabi, in collaboration with Musée National Picasso-Paris and



France Muséums, the exhibition on till May 31, marks a defining moment for the museum: its first exhibition, dedicated entirely to Pablo Picasso.

The game-changer

To speak of Picasso means speaking of modern art itself. Few artists have altered the course of visual culture with such invention, audacity and range. Across more than seven decades, Picasso refused to be confined by a single style, movement, or medium. He painted, sculpted, sketched, engraved, experimented with ceramics, and dismantled artistic



Forms in flux The works reveal how Picasso bent form into emotion, invention and force. PHOTOS: NEETA LAL

conventions with fearless intensity, only to rebuild them into something entirely new.

What makes *Picasso, the Figure* compelling is how elegantly it captures the breadth of that genius. The exhibition brings together around 60 important works exploring Picasso’s fascination with the human figure – from cubist experiments to his neoclassical portraits, surrealist compositions, and boldly expressive late works. Picasso’s early portraits still carry traces of academic discipline. Faces appear balanced, recognisable, almost obedient to conventional structure. But as you move deeper into the exhibition, those rules

begin to dissolve. Features shift. Profiles fracture. Eyes migrate. Bodies refuse to remain whole.

“Picasso never treated portraiture as an exercise in resemblance,” the guide informs. “For him, the human face was never fixed, but fluid – emotional, fragmented, and psychologically charged.” It becomes impossible not to recall his famous observations: a head, he once remarked, is simply a matter of eyes, nose, and mouth – arranged as one pleases. That philosophy resonates from every wall.

Muses and reinvention

One of the exhibition’s arresting works is ‘Portrait of a seated woman’ (Olga) from 1923. Depicting a lady named Olga Khokhlova, the painting offers a striking contrast to Picasso’s Cubist experimentation. She sits with quiet elegance, her face turned gently away, expression composed yet elusive.

Following his immersion in classical art and Renaissance masterpieces during travels through Italy, Picasso temporarily

returned to a more refined, neoclassical language. The result feels almost sculptural. Olga appears less painted than carved, like a Greco-Roman figure suspended in stillness. There is tenderness here, but also distance. Further into the exhibition, that softness gives way to something bolder. In ‘Woman in an armchair’ (1947), Picasso turns his attention to Françoise Gilot – one of the defining women of his later life. But this is no conventional portrait. Gilot appears transformed into something botanical, almost mythological. Her body elongates like a stem, her limbs branch outward like leaves or claws, and her face blooms within petal-like forms. The work is playful, sensual, and faintly unsettling – all at once.

Picasso rarely painted women as mere individuals, but as forces – emotional, symbolic, transformative. Throughout the exhibition, the maestro’s influences reveal themselves in layers – African masks, ancient mythology, Iberian sculpture and classical European masters. Picasso absorbed visual languages from across cultures and centuries, only to dismantle them and reconstruct them into something unmistakably his own. Yet beneath the experimentation, another force quietly begins to dominate: conflict.

As Europe descended into violence, Picasso’s work grew darker, sharper, and emotionally heavier. And nowhere is his legacy felt more powerfully than in the exhibition’s final galleries, where his influence extends far beyond Europe.

In a darkened room, Iraqi artist Dia Al-Azzawi’s monumental ‘Elegy to My trapped city’, presides. Long, horizontal, and emotionally overwhelming, the painting echoes the visual language of Picasso’s anti-war masterpieces while speaking directly to the destruction of Baghdad. Figures writhe across the canvas in anguish, accompanied by the haunting sound of Arabic poetry filling the space. The effect is devastating.

It is here that *Picasso, the Figure* transforms from an art historical exhibition into something profound – a conversation across continents and generations.